
SESSION 4C

TWO CRUCIAL WEAPONS & PITFALLS

TWO CRUCIAL WEAPONS

Just as every soldier is issued battle gear upon entering the service, Christians, too, are provided complete spiritual armor when we enter the Lord's army.

Our equipment is described in Ephesians 6:10-20.



EPHESIANS 6:10-20 (ESV)

¹⁰ Finally, be strong in the Lord and in the strength of his might. ¹¹ Put on the whole armor of God, that you may be able to stand against the schemes of the devil. ¹² For we do not wrestle against flesh and blood, but against the rulers, against the authorities, against the cosmic powers over this present darkness, against the spiritual forces of evil in the heavenly places. ¹³ Therefore take up the whole armor of God, that you may be able to withstand in the evil day, and having done all, to stand firm. ¹⁴ Stand therefore, having fastened on the belt of truth, and having put on the breastplate of righteousness, ¹⁵ and, as shoes for your feet, having put on the readiness given by the gospel of peace. ¹⁶ In all circumstances take up the shield of faith, with which you can extinguish all the flaming darts of the evil one; ¹⁷ and take the helmet of salvation, and the sword of the Spirit, which is the word of God, ¹⁸ praying at all times in the Spirit, with all prayer and supplication. To that end keep alert with all perseverance, making supplication for all the saints, ¹⁹ and also for me, that words may be given to me in opening my mouth boldly to proclaim the mystery of the gospel, ²⁰ for which I am an ambassador in chains, that I may declare it boldly, as I ought to speak.

A close reading of the Ephesians 6 passage shows that all the pieces of the armor described until the first half of vs. 17 are **defensive**. Then, in vs. 17-20, the imagery shifts to the first **offensive** weapon in the list, the "sword of the Spirit, which is the word of God."



LUKE 4:1-13 (ESV)

And Jesus, full of the Holy Spirit, returned from the Jordan and was led by the Spirit in the wilderness ²for forty days, being tempted by the devil. And he ate nothing during those days. And when they were ended, he was hungry. ³ The devil said to him, "If you are the Son of God, command this stone to become bread." ⁴ And Jesus answered him, "It is written, 'Man shall not live by bread alone.' " ⁵ And the devil took him up and showed him all the kingdoms of the world in a moment of time, ⁶ and said to him, "To you I will give all this authority and their glory, for it has been delivered to me, and I give it to whom I will. ⁷ If you, then, will worship me, it will all be yours." ⁸ And Jesus answered him, "It is written,

“You shall worship the Lord your God,
and him only shall you serve.”

⁹ And he took him to Jerusalem and set him on the pinnacle of the temple and said to him, "If you are the Son of God, throw yourself down from here," ¹⁰ for it is written,

“He will command his angels concerning you,
to guard you,”

¹¹ and

“On their hands they will bear you up,
lest you strike your foot against a stone.”

¹² And Jesus answered him, "It is said, 'You shall not put the Lord your God to the test.' " ¹³ And when the devil had ended every temptation, he departed from him until an opportune time.

LUKE 8:11-12 (ESV)

¹¹ Now the parable is this: The seed is the word of God. ¹² The ones along the path are those who have heard; then the devil comes and takes away the word from their hearts, so that they may not believe and be saved.

What can we learn from the above passages about the role of the Word of God in living victoriously?

HISTORY BELONGS TO THE INTERCESSORS

Notice how the Ephesians 6 passage ends with repeated exhortations to prayer (vv. 18-20). Indeed, prayer, along with the word of God, is the main way that we wage spiritual warfare.

As we have already established in the previous sections of this chapter, this world is contested territory. God's will is not always done. One of the ways that God's will becomes established on earth is through the prayers of his children. The Apostle Paul in Ephesians 6, and Jesus in Matthew 6 call us to engage in this kind of prayer.

It is one of the most powerful ways we can battle against the forces of Satan.

History Belongs to the Intercessors

Intercession is spiritual defiance of what is, in the name of what God has promised. Intercession visualizes an alternative future to the one apparently fated by the momentum of current contradictory forces. [...]

There is a marvelous image of intercession in the Book of Revelation. [...]

Now when the Lamb broke the seventh seal, there was silence in heaven for about half an hour. I saw the seven angels who stand in the presence of God: they were given seven trumpets.

Another angel came and stood at the altar, holding a golden censer. He was given much incense to offer with the prayers of all God's people on the golden altar in front of the throne, and the smoke of the incense from the angel's hand went up before God with his people's prayers. The angel took the censer, filled it with fire from the altar, and threw it down on the earth; and there came peals of thunder, lightning-flashes, and an earthquake. (Rev. 8:1-5, REB)

Heaven itself falls silent. The heavenly hosts and celestial spheres suspend their ceaseless singing so that the prayers of the saints on earth can be heard. [...]

This scene reverses the usual unrolling of fate, where heavenly decisions are acted out on earth. Human beings have intervened in the heavenly liturgy. [...] The unexpected becomes suddenly possible, because people on earth have invoked heaven, the home of the possibles, and have been heard. What happens next happens because people prayed.

The message is clear: *history belongs to the intercessors, who believe the future into being.* [...] These shapers of the future are the intercessors, who call out of the future the longed-for new present.¹

If the future is thus open, if the heavenly hosts must be silenced so that God can listen to the prayers of the saints and act accordingly, then we are no longer dealing with the unchanging, immutable God of Stoic metaphysics. Before that unchangeable God, whose whole will was fixed from all eternity, intercession is ridiculous. There is no place for intercession with a God whose will is incapable of change. What Christians have too long worshiped is the God of Stoicism, to whose immutable will we can only surrender ourselves, conforming our wills to the unchangeable will of deity.

Not so with biblical prayer. Scripture calls us into the presence of Yahweh of Hosts, who chooses circuitous paths in the desert and whose ways are subject to change without notice. This is a God who works with us and for us, to make and keep human life humane. [...]

When Abraham discovers that Yahweh is about to destroy Sodom, where his nephew Lot lives with his wife and two daughters, Abraham blocks God's path: "Suppose there are fifty righteous within the city; will you then sweep away the place and not forgive it for the fifty righteous who are in it? Far be it from you to do such a thing . . . ! Shall not the Judge of all the earth do what is just?" When God agrees to spare Sodom if there are fifty, Abraham presses the issue: Would you spare the city if there were forty? Thirty? Twenty? Ten? God agrees, and though ten are not found there, God saves Lot's family, though they are but four (Genesis 18). Moral: it pays to haggle with God.

Martin Luther understood this aspect of prayer well: "Our Lord God could not but hear me; I threw the sack down before his door. I rubbed God's ear with all his promises about hearing prayer."⁷

Scripture is full of this motif of spirited give-and-take with God. When Israel, impatient from waiting forty days for Moses to return from Sinai, makes the golden calf, God says to Moses: You'd better get down there. Israel has made a golden calf, and I'm fed up with dealing with them. "I have seen this people, how stiff-necked they are. Now let me alone, so that my wrath may burn hot against them and I may consume them; and of you I will make a great nation" (Exod. 32:9-10).

Moses refuses to let God destroy Israel: Yahweh, why should your wrath blaze out against this people of yours whom you brought out of the land of Egypt with arm outstretched and mighty hand? Why let the Egyptians say, "Ah, it was in treachery that he brought them out, to do them to death in the mountains and wipe them off the face of the earth"? Leave your burning wrath; repent and do not bring this evil on your people.

And we read, "The Lord repented of the evil which he thought to do to his people." Moses made Yahweh repent (Exod. 32:14, RSV)!

[...]

Nor is this theme confined to the Hebrew Scriptures. We see it in Jesus' parables of the Persistent Widow and the Friend who Came at Midnight, both examples of how we are to hammer away in prayer until a breakthrough comes (Luke 18:1-8; 11:5-13). [...]

No doubt our intercessions sometimes change us as we open ourselves to new possibilities we had not guessed. No doubt our prayers to God reflect back upon us as a divine command to become the answer to our prayer. But if we are to take the biblical understanding seriously at all, intercession is more than that. It changes the world and it changes what is possible to God. It creates an island of relative freedom in a world gripped by an unholy necessity. A new force field appears that hitherto was only potential. The entire configuration changes as the result of the change of a single part. An aperture opens in the praying person, permitting God to act without violating human freedom. The change in even one person thus changes what God can thereby do in that world.²

God is the Intercessor

All this about our role as intercessors in creating history is arrogant bravado unless we recognize that it is God rather than ourselves who initiates prayer, and that it is God's power, not ours, that answers to the world's needs. We are always preceded in intercession. God is always already praying within us. When we turn to pray, it is already the second step of prayer. We join with God in a prayer already going on in us and in the world.

The Spirit also helps us in our present limitations. For example, we do not know how to pray worthily, but God's Spirit within us is actually praying for us in those agonizing longings ["groans"] which cannot find words. Those who know the heart's secrets understand the Spirit's intention as they pray according to God's will for those who love God. (Rom. 8:26-27, Phillips, with revisions)

¹ Wink, Walter. *Engaging the Powers: Discernment and Resistance in a World of Dominion*. Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 1992. pp. 298-299.

² Ibid. p. 301-302.

This groaning of the Holy Spirit within us echoes and gathers up two other groanings mentioned in the previous paragraph: the groaning of the whole creation in pangs of childbirth (Rom. 8:22); and we ourselves, who groan inwardly as we await the ultimate transformation--the redemption of our bodies (8:23).

The Spirit gathers up all this pain and releases it through us with sighs too deep for words. These sighs are not our own sighs, given articulation by the Spirit. They are the actual groanings of the Spirit within us, and they must be given articulation by us.³

Prayer and the Powers

Prayer is not just a two-way transaction. It also involves the great socio-spiritual forces that preside over so much of reality. I am speaking of the massive institutions and social structures and systems that dominate our world today, and of the spirituality at their center. If we wish to recover a sense of the importance of these Powers in prayer, we can scarcely do better than to consult the Book of Daniel. Daniel marks the moment when the role of the Powers in blocking answers to prayer was, for the first time, revealed to humanity.

[...] When the story opens, Daniel is in deep mourning and fasting for his people. [...] After twenty-one days an angel came and said, "Daniel, don't be afraid. God has heard your prayers ever since the first day you decided to humble yourself in order to gain understanding. I have come in answer to your prayer."

Why then was the angel twenty-one days in arriving, if the prayer was heard on the very first day that Daniel prayed? Because, the angel continues, "the angel prince of the kingdom of Persia opposed me for twenty-one days." He could not even have managed to get through to Daniel at all, except that "Michael, one of the chief angels, came to help me, because I had been left there alone" to contend with the angel of Persia. Now, while Michael occupies the angel of Persia, the messenger-angel has slipped through and is able to deliver the vision of the future for Daniel's exiled people. [...]

The angel of Persia is able to block God's messenger from answering Daniel's prayer! For twenty-one days Daniel contends with unseen spiritual powers. [...]

Daniel continues praying and fasting, God's angel continues to wrestle to get past the angel of Persia, yet nothing is apparently happening. God seems not to have answered the prayer. Despite this apparent indifference, however, there is a fierce war being waged in heaven between contending powers. [...]

This is an accurate depiction, in mythological terms, of the actual experience we have in prayer. [...]

Notice that the Bible makes no attempt to justify the delay in God's response. It is simply a fact of experience. We do not know why God cannot do "better," or why, for example, Michael is not sent to the aid of the messenger angel sooner. It is a deep mystery. [...]

In short, prayer involves not just God and people, but God and people and the Powers. What God is able to do in the world is hindered, to a considerable extent, by the rebelliousness, resistance, and self-interest of the Powers exercising their freedom under God.

[...]

Prayer is not magic; it does not always "work." It is not something we do, but a response to what God is already doing within us and the world. Our prayers are the necessary opening that allows God to act without violating our freedom. Prayer is the ultimate act of partnership with God. Therefore God allows no groveling. Daniel throws himself on his face before the divine messenger, but the angel touches him and rouses him to his hands and knees. The angel orders him, "Stand on your feet." Daniel does, but cannot speak or stop trembling. The angel touches his lips, and again his body, infusing him with the strength and power to speak the message he has received. God is no eastern potentate demanding obeisance. God puts us on our feet, fills us with power, and sends us on our way.

The sobering news that the Powers can thwart God is more than matched by the knowledge that our intercessions will ultimately prevail. Whether we have to wait twenty-one days or twenty-one years or twenty-one centuries changes nothing for faith. ⁴

- Walter Wink, *Engaging the Powers: Discernment and Resistance in a World of Dominion*

What are some ideas or phrases you want to remember from the excerpt?

³ Ibid. p. 304.

⁴ Ibid. pp. 308-331.

How does prayer function in the tension between God's will and the "powers"?

THE LORD'S PRAYER

Jesus himself urged us to pray against the forces that resist God in our world.



MATTHEW 6:9-13 (ESV)

⁹ Pray then like this:

“Our Father in heaven,
hallowed be your name.

¹⁰ Your kingdom come,
your will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.

¹¹ Give us this day our daily bread,

¹² and forgive us our debts,
as we also have forgiven our debtors.

¹³ And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.”

What does vs. 10 imply about God's will being done on earth?

What is the disciple's responsibility regarding God's will being done on earth?

- **What is the relationship between not understanding that we are in the midst of spiritual battle and ... negligence in spiritual disciplines, including lack of fervent intercessory prayer?**

- **What is the relationship between not understanding that we are in the midst of spiritual battle and ... lack of clear identity and mission?**